50

The Gandhi–Irwin Pact 1931

The quest to make Bhagat Singh's ideas better known, however, is mired in the enigma of whether his death was preventable. And if so, by whom? A growing body of evidence suggests that Gandhi did not do all he could to save Bhagat Singh from being executed. The late V.N. Datta, in his book *Gandhi and Bhagat Singh*, has recounted the raging debate from its earliest days, as he drew attention to each of the protagonists, for and against, the role of Gandhi, in whether he could or could not have saved Bhagat Singh. Taking a nuanced approach, he did not flinch from accepting that 'Gandhi regarded Singh's mode of militant nationalism, and the extreme left-wing political activity as the most injurious to the cause of Indian independence'.[1] However, he was nevertheless clear that Bhagat Singh could not have been saved by Gandhi because 'the assumption that Gandhi and Irwin were sovereign shapers of events . . . is questionable' in that 'they were working under constraints, which set limits to their actions'.[2] He is in no doubt that 'Gandhi put the maximum pressure on the Viceroy Lord Irwin for the commutation of the death sentence of Bhagat Singh and his comrades',[3] but that tragically it was all to no avail. However, a markedly different view was taken much earlier by G.S. Deol, when writing in 1969 he suggested that 'Mahatma Gandhi did not make it a condition of the settlement, though he could have done' because 'Gandhi himself wrote in his *Young India*, "I might have made commutation a term of the settlement. It could not be so made . . . The Working Committee had agreed with me in not making commutation a condition precedent to truce. I could, therefore, only mention it."' Deol goes on to say, 'But a "leader" who could go to the extent of stating to the Viceroy, that "if the boys should be hanged, they had